the borders of the Soviet Union.' " Tolubko was in no hurry to disclose the place of service to the officers, implying that he himself did not know it. But he added: "When you return, your names will be inscribed in golden letters on marble plaques."[4]

Tolubko honored Romny with his presence for a reason. The 43rd Division located in that city had already been chosen as the main missile unit to be sent to Cuba in the first draft of the Operation Anadyr planning proposal, approved by Khrushchev and his party colleagues on May 24. The document read: "To send to Cuba the 43rd Missile Division (commander of the division Major General Statsenko), comprising five missile regiments." Igor Statsenko was a forty-three-year-old graduate of the General Staff Academy who had received his general's epaulettes in April 1962, a few weeks before his name appeared in the proposal. A native of the town of Chornobyl, where a devastating nuclear disaster would take place in 1986, he fought in air defense units during the Second World War and stayed with them afterward.[5]

Tall and lean, with a full head of black hair, Statsenko was well regarded by superiors and subordinates alike. "Always looking smart, in irreproachable form on the parade ground and in daily activity, a lover of poetry who wrote verse himself and sang in his circle of friends and, most important, unforgettably devoted to military life, Igor Demianovich [Statsenko] was for me personally a model officer, general and citizen," wrote one of his subordinates later. General Gribkov, who entered Statsenko's name in the very first planning document, had an equally high opinion of him: effective, energetic, and always in good humor. Some considered Statsenko too ambitious, but others believed that he had just the right amount of drive and ambition. How otherwise could a native of a small Ukrainian town in the middle of nowhere have risen to become commander of a missile division at the age of forty-two and a general at the age of forty-three?[6]

The Strategic Missile Forces were only a year and a half old when Statsenko joined them in the summer of 1961. The division (which began as a brigade) was formed only a year before Statsenko's arrival in Romny, and he literally had to build it from scratch: most of his time was taken up with overseeing the construction of launchpads for missiles. The job would take